



*Odin and his wife Frigg were surveying the shining halls and temples of Asgard.*

“We need a wall to offer us protection from the giants and trolls,” said Odin. At that moment a stranger arrived, riding an enormous horse called Svadilfari. “I can help you,” he said. “In three seasons I’ll build a wall that no one will be able to breach. But in return I want to marry the goddess Freya, and take for myself the Sun and Moon.”

There was uproar among the gods when Odin told them of this offer. “I refuse to marry a stranger,” Freya said. “And without the Sun and Moon we’ll be groping around in the dark like moles.” Everyone agreed – until smooth-talking Loki spoke.

“What if we tell him to finish the wall in only one season?” he said. “He’ll never be able to manage that. He’ll go away empty-handed and we’ll at least have part of a wall built.”

So Odin put this new offer to the stranger. “All right,” he said.

*“But only if I can use my horse, and you promise not to harm me while I work.”*

With these terms agreed, the stranger set about his task.

Days turned to weeks, weeks turned to months, and Odin and Frigg looked on with worried frowns. With the help of his horse, which was far stronger than they had realized, the stranger had nearly completed the wall – only the gate remained unfinished.